



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Valley Christian Schools
School Website: <https://www.vcschools.org/>

December 27, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Valley Christian Schools (VCS) presents a strongly theocentric, formation-oriented approach to education with clear commitments to Biblical worldview, Reformed Christian foundations, and active family partnerships. When weighed against the classical-school rubric, VCS demonstrates robust alignment in Religious and Metaphysical Foundations, School Purpose and Goal, Faculty, and Parents & Community. Its curriculum and pedagogy reflect a traditional, faith-centered approach with explicit emphasis on spiritual formation, character formation, and a community of learners anchored in Christian confession. While it exhibits many classical markers, it does not consistently articulate or implement the core liberal-arts sequence (grammar, logic, rhetoric) or a Great Books-centric curriculum, which depresses it from a full "Classical" rating in Curriculum and, to a lesser extent, in Pedagogy. Overall, the school earns a CLASSICAL classification, with Element 3 (Curriculum) most clearly not fully classical, and Element 4 (Pedagogy) appearing SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than fully Classical.

Key insights at a glance - Religious & Metaphysical Foundations: Strong, explicit emphasis on Biblical worldview, Reformed tradition, liturgical rhythm (chapels, Bible studies, devotions), and the sacred in everyday learning. This aligns strongly with classical expectations in this dimension. Evidence: Our Beliefs; Spiritual Formation; Who We Are statements describing theology-infused learning, chapel-based practice, and a Coram Deo stance.

- Purpose & Goal: Education framed as formation—moral, spiritual, intellectual—within a Christian context and partnership with families; emphasis on equipping students for service and lifelong growth rather than mere vocational preparation. This is highly classical in spirit. Evidence: Who We Are; Our Beliefs statements describing formation and partnership with families. - Curriculum: Strong emphasis on Bible, Christian worldview, and arts integration; explicit Great Books/Great Conversation language is not present; liberal-arts canon (grammar, logic, rhetoric) is not foregrounded in public materials. This yields a notable deviation from a textbook classical curriculum. Evidence: Academics, Bible-centered curriculum; Arts emphasis; absence of explicit Great Books/grammar-logic-rhetoric triad in public-facing curriculum. - Pedagogy: Time-tested, faith-integrated pedagogy with memory- and performance-oriented elements (chants/singing in lower grades, chapel-based formation, advisement), but lacking explicit evidence of Socratic seminars or rhetoric-centric high-school pedagogy in public materials. This suggests a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL stance rather than fully classical pedagogy. Evidence: Lower-school singing/memory approaches described; upper-school emphasis on chapel-integrated and faith-based formation; absence of explicit Socratic/seminar language in public-facing pedagogy. - Faculty: Described as virtuous, caring, and model teachers; living curriculum and mentors; teachers depicted as partners with students in a faith-centered, academically serious environment. This aligns with classical expectations. Evidence: Middle School faculty description; "living curriculum" and teacher-student partnership language. - Parents & Community: Strong partnership with families, expectations of parental involvement, and opportunities for parent formation through events and communications. Evidence: Who We Are statements and repeated emphasis on partnership with parents; community engagement described in weekly news and event planning.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Public materials emphasize Biblical worldview, Reformed tradition, and theology as foundational to all study (Our Beliefs; Doctrinal Statements; Coram Deo). Chapels, Bible studies, and faith integration are described as central to formation.
 - Language indicates a liturgical rhythm and communal worship as integral to education (Spiritual Formation; Our Beliefs; Doctrinal Statements).
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords present: biblical worldview, theology, liturgy/chapel, Coram Deo, Reformed Tradition, sacred/holy, worship, prayer, spiritual formation, Bible studies, divine order, timeless truths.
 - Negative keywords present: none detected in public materials.
 - Estimated frequency: high density of positive keywords; near zero negative keywords.
- Why this rating
 - The school's core identity is overtly theological and liturgically oriented; faith shapes curriculum, campus life, and community expectations. This aligns strongly with Classical expectations for a transcendent moral realism and liturgical-communal practices dimension. The lexicon of "theology," "chapel," "Biblical Worldview," and "Coram Deo" anchors this category as CLASSICAL. Evidence aligns with the positive-keyword set for this element. See Our Beliefs and Spiritual Formation materials cited above.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Public materials frame education as formation aimed at virtue, wisdom, and flourishing, not merely information or job preparation; emphasis on partnership with families for holistic development; aim to equip and inspire for lifelong service to Christ.
 - Descriptions of "formation" across mind, body, and spirit, with attention to character and spiritual growth.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords present: formation, virtue, human flourishing, wisdom, teleology/purpose (telos), truth/goodness/beauty, Christian worldview, family partnership, lifelong discipleship.
 - Negative keywords present: none strongly detected (no emphasis on secular job-prep or "21st-century skills" language in public materials).
 - Estimated frequency: predominantly positive keywords; minimal if any negative signals.
- Why this rating
 - The school explicitly embraces formation and virtue-centered aims, which map closely to the classical Element 2 criteria. The language of "formation" and "virtuous life" and the explicit Christian telos (pursuit of truth, goodness, and beauty) align with the Positive Keyword indicators for this category. See Our Beliefs and Who We Are materials.

Element 3: School Curriculum — NOT CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Curriculum descriptions emphasize Bible, Christian worldview, and standards-based subjects (Bible, language arts, social studies, science, math) with a strong arts emphasis; no explicit emphasis on the liberal-arts trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric) or Great Books/Great Conversation; no widespread reference to Latin/Greek or quadrivium. Public materials highlight core subjects and faith integration rather than a classical liberal-arts canon.
 - Public pages show grade-level core curricula (e.g., Seventh/Eighth Grade cores) and Bible courses; Arts integration is highlighted (Broadway Showcases, Arts Home). There is no explicit Great Books program noted in public-facing content.

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- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords (classical lexicon) present: (limited) history-based study and liberal-arts references appear only tangentially via general “curriculum,” “art,” and “Bible.”
 - Negative keywords present: explicit classical-lexicon indicators such as “Great Books,” “grammar, logic, rhetoric” or “Socratic pedagogy” are not present in the public-facing curriculum materials; there is no explicit emphasis on Latin/Greek, quadrivium, or the Great Conversation.
 - Estimated frequency: few if any classical-positive curriculum keywords; clear absence of core classical-curriculum indicators.
 - Why this rating
 - While the school provides a rigorous, faith-centered curriculum, it does not foreground the liberal-arts canon or the Great Books framework that defines a Classical School’s Curriculum category. The absence of explicit grammar-logic-rhetoric emphasis and Great Books content in public-facing materials leads to a NOT CLASSICAL rating for this category. See Academics and Elementary/Middle School curricula pages for public content.

Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Pedagogical practices described include memory-friendly, faith-centered learning (chapels, devotions, Bible study; singing and memory in lower grades) and a strong emphasis on community, advisement, and age-appropriate curricula; high-school pedagogy (Socratic methods, seminars, debates) is not explicitly described in public-facing materials, though the school offers upper-level rhetoric training in some programs (e.g., speech opportunities in broader programs). The public materials emphasize formation and community rather than explicit Socratic seminars or classical rhetoric-based pedagogy.
 - There is explicit use of singing and memory-work in lower grades and a strong emphasis on “wonder” and experiential learning in some arts programs, but no robust documentation of regular Socratic seminars or formal rhetoric training at the high-school level in public pages.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords present: scholé/restful learning, singing/memory in lower grades, reverence/-wonder, chapel-based learning, formal Bible/chapel integration.
 - Negative keywords present: lack of explicit Socratic seminars, lack of formal Great Books or rhetoric-based capstone or oratorical programs in public materials.
 - Estimated frequency: moderate positive signals surrounding contemplative, memory-based, and faith-integrated pedagogy; limited presence of classical-pedagogy markers (Socratic seminars, rhetoric-based assessment).
- Why this rating
 - The school’s pedagogy shows meaningful alignment with contemplative, formation-focused methods (Scholé-like elements and memory work) but does not consistently demonstrate the hallmark classical pedagogy of Socratic seminars, rigorous dialectic, or rhetoric-focused public-speaking programs across the high-school level. This yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating for Pedagogy. See Spiritual Formation and Middle/Elementary academic pages for evidence of memory-based and faith-integrated pedagogy; lack of explicit Socratic/seminar language in public content supports the nuanced ranking.

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Faculty are described as “model teachers and mentors,” living the curriculum and forming a core of the school culture; teachers are portrayed as caring, virtuous, and deeply committed to students and God, with a collaborative, “faculty as living curriculum” ethos. This matches classical expectations of the faculty as exemplars and mentors who model virtue and knowledge.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: model teachers, mentors, living curriculum, faculty of friends, collegial culture, moral exemplars, teaching with faith, partnership with students.
- Negative keywords present: none obvious in public-facing content.
- Estimated frequency: high presence of positive keywords; negligible negative signals.
- Why this rating
 - The public materials describe a faculty culture that aligns with classical expectations of the teacher as a virtuous exemplar and partner in formation, i.e., the living curriculum and a mentorship model. This clearly supports a CLASSICAL rating for Faculty. Evidence: Middle School teachers page and related faculty descriptions.

Element 6: School Parents and Community — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - The school emphasizes partnership with families, parental involvement (e.g., “founding concept of parental involvement” and ongoing parent-faculty partnership), and open invitations for parent engagement and formation through events and communications. The materials describe a long-standing culture of parental involvement that extends into the school’s program, communications, and governance.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords present: partnership with families, co-teachers, parental involvement, community of learners, parent formation, home-school partnership, open campus, parent participation.
 - Negative keywords present: none detected in public materials.
 - Estimated frequency: strong presence of positive keywords; no negative signals.
- Why this rating
 - Valley Christian Schools actively recruits and sustains parent involvement and partnership, a core classical-keyword indicator for Element 6. Evidence shows explicit language about parental partnership and family engagement.

Overall Assessment (Aggregate)

- Categorical scores:
 - Element 1: CLASSICAL
 - Element 2: CLASSICAL
 - Element 3: NOT CLASSICAL
 - Element 4: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
 - Element 5: CLASSICAL
 - Element 6: CLASSICAL
- Aggregate ranking: CLASSICAL
- Rationale: The school demonstrates robust alignment with classical education’s religious, formation, and community dimensions, particularly in Religious & Metaphysical Foundations, School Purpose & Goal, Faculty, and Parents & Community. The Curriculum category does not align with the classical liberal-arts canon (no explicit Great Books, grammar-logic-rhetoric sequence) and Pedagogy shows some classical features (restful/remember-based, faith-integrated) but lacks explicit Socratic-seminar methodology across core grades. Taken together, the weight of evidence across six categories supports an overall CLASSICAL classification, with Element 3 as a notable deviation and Element 4 as a partial (Somewhat Classical) alignment.

What Would Move the Needle (note: applied only if SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL; not required for CLASSICAL)

- For Element 4 (Pedagogy): Adopt a more explicit classical-pedagogy framework, incorporating Socratic seminars, dialectic activities, and formal rhetoric instruction in upper grades; integrate regular, planned opportunities for students to deliver orations, debates, and public speaking with guided feedback.

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- For Element 3 (Curriculum): Introduce a formal liberal-arts sequence (grammar, logic, rhetoric) and clearly map a “Great Books/Great Conversation” track within the upper grades; include Latin or Greek options and a canonical Western Civ sequence to align with classical canon.
 - For Element 4 (Pedagogy) and Element 3 (Curriculum): Provide explicit alignment language on the website that ties daily practice to classical-pedagogy markers (scholé days, memory work, recitation, memorized passages, etc.).
 - For Communications: Add a public-facing summary of the Great Books/Great Conversation rhetoric approach to ensure prospective families understand the classical goals and how the school intends to implement them.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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